

SALES TRAINING DEBRIEF · SESSION 6

Use the Checklist. Connection Beats Technique.

Session led by Corie Dawson, Director

Thursday 14 May 2026 · Internal sales-team summary

The thesis in one line

Every pitch is the same pitch. Affordability first, product second, price last. The reps who close are the ones who run the checklist on every call — and who treat the conversation as connection, not extraction. Connection is the master skill, because it lets you survive your own mistakes.

“Once you have a connection on anything, it's very easy for things to pass through. Humans are no different. If you want to be a brilliant salesperson, you need to be the universal adapter that can plug into any prospect.” — Corie (paraphrased)

1. The materials only work if you use them

The session opened with a sharp moment. Corie asked the team to run through the affordability formula on a new prospect (a camper-van conversion business). The team couldn't. The reason: they hadn't fully worked through the training materials that have been published in the team portal.

“I've taken the time to put things on the page for you to read and understand. If you don't take the time to learn it, you're wasting your time and wasting mine.” — Corie

What this means for the team

Each training session produces five resources: the debrief Word doc, the visual toolkit PDF, the podcast, the presentation, and the quiz. They are sequenced deliberately — read it, reference it, listen to it, watch it, get tested on it. Skipping the back half (podcast, presentation, quiz) leaves significant gaps that show up in real pitches.

The minimum bar

- Before any pitch, the rep should have completed all five resources from the most recent two sessions.
- Take the quiz seriously — score below 80% means the material didn't stick. Re-read the debrief. Re-take.
- Treat the toolkit PDF like a pilot's pre-flight checklist. Walk through it on every pitch.
- Don't wing pitches. You have the answers — open the book.

"I keep the checklist in front of me every time I fly. I know what's on it better than you do — and I still pull it out. Why? So I don't make mistakes. Humans make mistakes. That's why the checklist exists." — Corie (paraphrased)

2. Every pitch is the same pitch

A central correction in the session: reps are treating each prospect as a unique problem requiring fresh analysis on the call. They are not. Every pitch follows the same sequence:

1. Calculate affordability (Session 2 + 3 formula). Service business = staff × \$100k. Trade business = staff × \$100k × 3.
2. Break it down weekly. Annual turnover ÷ 50 weeks = weekly value. That sets the price anchor.
3. Read the prospect's situation. Are they trying to grow, hold steady, or contracting? Match the pitch energy to that.
4. Build the pitch around their goal, not your product. Lead with what they told you they want.
5. Pitch high. Show the stack. Let them choose.
6. Run the diagnostic if they hesitate. Isolate the variable. Hard-close with a deadline.
7. Assume the close. Pivot to deposit and scheduling.

Every step of that sequence is in the toolkit. The team's job is to run the sequence — not to invent a new one each time.

Worked example — the camper-van prospect

One-person operation. Eight to nine jobs a year at ~\$80k each = ~\$640k annual revenue. Materials likely consume 70% (it's a trade business with significant inputs), so margin ≈ \$192k. Apply the rule: 1 staff × \$100k × 3 = \$300k for a trade business — which puts the affordability ballpark close to the customer's self-reported number. Weekly value ≈ \$5k. No employees because the operator is choosing to stay small. Pitching position: this is maintenance, not growth — frame the pitch as insurance protecting an already-good business, not as a growth lever.

3. Block the exits before the prospect takes them

A predictable failure mode: the rep waits for the prospect to raise an objection, then tries to handle it. By the time the prospect has spoken the objection out loud, they have committed to it psychologically and they will defend it.

"Once a client takes a mental position on something — especially a verbal position — you're finished. There's no getting through to them." — Corie

The abalone principle

An abalone is a shellfish that sits on a rock. If you sneak up on it, you can prise it off with a knife. If it senses you coming, it suckers down to the rock so hard that a crane couldn't move

it. Prospects work the same way. Once they sucker down on a position ("I don't want too many leads," "I need to think about it," "I've got to talk to my partner"), they're fixed. The play is to prevent the position from forming.

How to block an exit

If you can predict what objection the prospect is likely to raise — based on their business situation — name it first, on your own terms, before they do.

"Look, I know you don't want a thousand people calling you. This isn't about that. Your website looks terrible, and with the new tax climate coming in, you could see a downturn. Treat this as an insurance policy — not as a growth lever." —
How it sounds in practice

Notice what just happened. The most likely objection ("I'm too busy for more leads") has been named, framed, and disposed of — before the prospect had a chance to take a position on it. They can't now use it as their exit, because the rep has already addressed it. The rep has chosen the framing.

4. Mirror their language back through your product

A core technique from the session, illustrated through what Corie called the "Zimbabwean restaurant" scenario. You sit down in a restaurant where the menu is in a language you can't read. The waiter doesn't recite every dish. Instead they ask: "What sort of food do you feel like? Chicken? Fish? Beef? You like spicy or mild?" You answer. Then the waiter packages your answers back to you in their format: "Perfect — we have a beautiful Zimbabwean chicken, a Zimbabwean beef, a Zimbabwean potato side. Shall I bring those?" You say yes, because they just sold you exactly what you said you wanted, plus a flavour name.

Translated for sales

They told you	Mirror it back as your product
Prospect says: "I want to blow up my business."	You say: "Perfect — here's our growth-focused package. We blow your phone up."
Prospect says: "I want to stay the size I am."	You say: "Perfect — this is a maintenance package, not a growth lever. We protect what you've built."
Prospect says: "I just want to look professional."	You say: "Perfect — let's talk about your website as your best salesperson when you're asleep."
Prospect says: "Just a few extra leads would be great."	You say: "Perfect — we're going to add an insurance layer that catches the leads you're currently missing."

The mechanic is: listen, take the customer's exact words, and re-deliver them inside the wrapping of your product. The customer feels heard (because you literally used their

language). The product feels custom-fit (because it's been described in their terms). And you've done almost no original sales work — you've repackaged their own brief.

5. The 90 / 10 / 1 conversation ratio

A reliable rule of thumb for what a closing conversation should sound like:

- **90% about the prospect.** Their business, their situation, their last three jobs, their concerns, their goals. You ask. They talk. You note. You ask another.
- **10% about the product.** Tailored from the 90%. The product is described in the language the prospect just gave you.
- **1% about the price.** At the end. Brief. Confident. With the assumption frame already running.

"When you guys talk to clients, your energy feels like take, take, take. Like you're sucking out information. That's not a conversation. That's an interrogation." — Corie (paraphrased)

How to make question extraction feel like conversation

- Wrap every fact-finding question with curiosity, not clinical interest. "Just out of interest — what was the last job you did?" not "What's the average job value?"
- Reflect back what they said before asking the next question. Shows you were listening.
- Find one thing genuinely interesting in their answer and explore it for a beat before moving on.
- Drop one small piece of yourself into the conversation — a comparable experience, a related story.
- Treat the prospect like a date you actually want a second one with. Not a transaction to close.

6. Connection is the master skill

Above every script, every objection-handling move, every diagnostic question — sits one underlying skill that determines whether they all work or all fail. Connection.

"Once you have a connection on anything, it's very easy for things to pass through. Same with humans. If you want to be a brilliant salesperson, you have to be the universal adapter that plugs into any prospect." — Corie (paraphrased)

Why connection matters more than technique

With connection, a prospect will tell you the real objection. Without it, they will tell you "let me think about it" and ghost the follow-up. With connection, you can say something slightly clumsy and still close the deal — they'll forgive the misstep because they like you. Without it, every flaw is fatal.

How a no-connection prospect speaks	How a connected prospect speaks
"Yeah, I want to think about it. I'll get back to you."	"Look, it's a bit more than I wanted to spend — what can you do?"
"Send me some info and I'll get back to you."	"Honestly, my partner controls the cash. Let me talk to them tonight."
"It sounds great, I just need to do my due diligence."	"I love it, but I need to know — can you actually deliver by month two?"
Polite. Generic. Ghosted within a week.	Specific. Honest. Closeable.

The difference is connection. Build it before you pitch.

7. The assumption close

A specific technique that Corie demonstrated at the end of the painter roleplay. After the pitch lands and the price is on the table, do not ask "are you interested?" Do not ask "would you like to proceed?" Assume the deal is happening and move to logistics.

"I'll send you the link. All I need from you is a \$400 deposit. Any particular day work best for your kick-off call with our project manager?" — How it sounds

Why it works

- You've done the hard part of the meeting. Asking "do you want to proceed?" invites them to re-open closed questions. Don't.
- Customers who genuinely want the product also want the meeting to end. They want to get to lunch. Help them.
- If they're going to apply the brakes, they will. But making them apply brakes is harder than letting them drift into a yes.
- The default of the conversation should be yes. Anything else is them having to actively pull out — which most people don't.

If they DO apply the brakes

Treat it gracefully. "Yeah, of course — I understand you need to talk to your partner. No stress. Let me give you a call Monday." Don't panic, don't back-pedal the price, don't over-explain. Lock in the next contact and move on. The graceful retreat preserves the connection for the second conversation.

8. Breaking the "salesperson" frame

Every prospect walks into a sales conversation with a default frame: "this is a salesperson, they want my money, I should be careful." Corie demonstrated a specific technique for breaking that frame in a car-yard scenario, which translates directly to phone and meeting sales.

The "just looking" interruption

Prospect says "I'm just looking." Most salespeople accept this and back off. Don't. Try this instead:

"'Funny way to feel.'" [They pause.] "I just said hello — I have to say hi or my boss gets angry. But seriously, anything I can help with, just let me know. I'll leave you to it.'" — The pattern interruption

This achieves three things at once: it disrupts the script the prospect was running, it gives them permission to NOT engage (which weirdly makes them want to), and it positions you as a human with a sense of humour rather than a salesperson with a quota. From this point onwards, the conversation is on different rails.

9. Tactical phrases for the week

Specific verbal moves that appeared in the session worth drilling individually:

Stop saying	Start saying
"What's your budget?"	"Just out of interest — where were you thinking, ballpark?"
"Are you interested?"	"Which one were you leaning toward — the gold or platinum?"
"Let me know if you have any questions."	"You've probably got a couple of questions for me — what comes to mind?"
"I'll send through the info."	"Got a couple of options to send you. Want me to break them down now or in a follow-up?"
Defensive: "It's actually only \$X."	Assumptive: "Let me see if I can get under \$Y for you — give me 15 minutes."

10. Behaviours to change this week

- Complete every training resource.** All five per session — debrief, toolkit, podcast, presentation, quiz. You cannot pitch what you haven't studied.
- Open the checklist on every pitch.** Calculate affordability before you say a single product word. Apply the formula every time.
- Predict and pre-empt the objection.** Before the prospect raises their natural objection, name it and frame it on your terms.
- Mirror their language.** Take the prospect's exact words and re-deliver them inside your product description.
- Hit the 90 / 10 / 1 ratio.** 90% about them, 10% about the product, 1% about the price. If you're monologuing, you're losing.

13. **Build connection first, technique second.** Without connection, every script fails. With it, you can recover from almost any mistake.
14. **Assume the close.** Skip "would you like to proceed?" Go straight to deposit and scheduling. Let them apply brakes if they need to.
15. **Add "just out of interest" to every potentially uncomfortable question.** Softens the ask. Keeps the conversation feeling like conversation, not interrogation.

Final reminder. The answers are in the materials. The materials only work if you actually use them. The checklist only works if you actually open it. Connection only forms if you actually listen. None of this is hidden — it's all in your hands. The work this week is the discipline of using what's already there.